

COUNTER INFORMATION

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SOLID AS A ROCK!

FITZWILLIAM, YORKSHIRE

"WE'LL STAY OUT TILL HELL FREEZES OVER" — a Fitzwilliam miner, 27th January 1985.

IF YOU'RE BEING taken in by the mass media propaganda that the miners strike is already defeated — visit Fitzwilliam in Yorkshire. Every single miner in the village is on strike.

The local Kinsley Drift mine, normally employing around 500, has a grand total of 2 strike-breakers. But in late January this figure was halved, when one scab failed to survive the weekly womens picket. None of the missiles that pounded his scab mobile actually hit him. Nevertheless he collapsed and had to be taken to hospital. The diagnosis? "An anxiety attack".

The miners and women who spoke to Counter Information told us how almost the whole community, including the unemployed and workers from other industries, are committed to the struggle.

The women described how they are fully involved: speaking at meetings, going to demos, organising and taking part in picketing, running the kitchen — despite the opposition of some 'male chauvinists'.

After experiencing the restrictive attitude of N.U.M. officials, the women now organise their pickets themselves — "its nothing to do with the Union", one said.

During the strike Fitzwilliam has seen sabotage against the colliery buildings, clashes with

the police, barricades in the streets — and vicious police brutality. "PC DIMMOCK — COMMUNITY SPY" is only one of the many slogans against the police, in support of the strike, and in solidarity with prisoners, that cover the village.

Up till recently flying pickets from Fitzwilliam spread the struggle beyond their own 'fortress', convoys of minibuses sometimes having to break through police roadblocks to reach their targets.

Since the New Year however the Yorkshire Area N.U.M. have taken away their minibuses, claiming that with sequestration the union has no more money — a claim that some miners dispute.



Free

TERRY FRENCH,
MINER JAILED FOR
FIVE YEARS

Whatever the truth may be, if the N.U.M. had time before sequestration to transfer massive funds abroad, they surely had time to buy minibuses to enable picketing to continue.

Another blow to the struggle has been the numerous arrests, accompanied by restrictive bail conditions and heavy court sentences.

Nevertheless the miners and women we spoke to in Fitzwilliam are determined to continue the struggle. This is a fight with a significance far beyond the coal industry.

One woman told us how she welcomed the support they were getting from gay and lesbian contingents on miners marches, the mining communities were now suffering the same sort of police oppression that groups like gays and blacks had suffered for years. Unlike the union officials who accept today's system of exploitation, the younger strikers are, one miner said, "a new breed" who would take the whole struggle much further — the Union leaders will either have to keep up with what's happening or they'll be left behind.

The struggle of the men and women in the mining communities should be an inspiration to all who are oppressed and exploited. They've shown that the best way to fight back is NOT to rely on Union leaders or politicians going through 'official channels', but to organise ourselves to take direct action.

We mustn't let this vicious government (aided and abetted by the compromising union leaders) succeed in isolating the miners. All those already involved in the struggle must directly approach other groups of workers and the unemployed and urge them to take action NOW, linking their struggle directly with the miners fight.



Picture JOHN STURROCK (Network)

Silverwood colliery in South Yorkshire

MONKTONHALL

THE COAL BOARD are again flouting a 'national agreement' — NACODS men at Monktonhall have been threatened by the manager, Kerr, that they won't be paid unless they go into work through miners picket lines.

But mass pickets at the Lothian colliery on February 4th succeeded in persuading the local Nacods members to continue their policy of not crossing the picket line. And the NACODS men have now withdrawn safety cover.

It's clear that the Coal Board will break any agreement whenever they think they can get away with it. When will NACODS members realise this and join the miners in all-out strike?

(Info.: pickets st Monktonhall, early February)

ONLY DOING THEIR JOB?

LOTHIAN police excelled themselves at Blinkbonny private mine in early January.

Striking miners succeeded in persuading 6 Blinkbonny men not to go into work. As they walked away from the picket line 2 of them were stopped by the police and asked where they were going. "Back to our bus", replied the Blinkbonny miners — whereupon the police promptly arrested them.

Can anyone still believe the police are neutral?

(Info: Monktonhall pickets, early February)

WHEELER, N.C.B. boss in Scotland, tried to use the recent fires at Frances and Seafield collieries to blackmail miners back to work.

But his move failed and the vast majority of Fife miners are still on strike. And they're determined not to allow any compulsory redundancies to result from the N.C.B.'s announced closure of the Frances.

So strong is the spirit in the Fife mining communities that the Police are now reluctant to venture into certain areas such as High Valleyfield, where police vehicles have come under attack.

PEOPLES NEED NOT BOSSES GREED

NEARLY 100 people took part in a day of direct action on the theme of PEOPLES NEED NOT BOSSES GREED in Edinburgh on 20th December.

The Electricity Board showrooms were briefly occupied in solidarity with the miners, pornographic magazines were destroyed in Menzies, while the Coal Board showroom, the Inland Revenue offices and fur shops were among the other targets.

PUBLISHED by Anarchists in Glasgow and Edinburgh.

WRITE to Box 81, First of May 43 Candlemaker Row, Edinburgh



FREE THE PRISONERS!

THE WHOLE MIGHT of the police, the courts and the entire State is being used to try and crush the miners strike. Up to the 14th December 7,316 people had been charged in connection with the strike. By the end of January at least 117 people had been given custodial sentences.

Many others are in jail awaiting trial.

In one prison alone — Armley Leeds — there were 150 miners in mid-December.

Police brutality has often been met by courageous resistance on the picket lines and in the pit villages such as Fitzwilliam, Hemsworth and Grimethorpe.

This solidarity must continue when people are imprisoned. A major aim of the strike must be the release of all prisoners and the dropping of all charges, with full re-instatement in their jobs for everybody sacked. The law has yielded before to mass direct action, such as when the jailed dockers — the Pentonville 5 — were freed.

It's also vital that those currently behind bars and their families are given as much practical support as possible.

Prisoners Aid groups are now being formed to do just this. The Fitzwilliam Prisoners Aid Committee was set up by miners and other local people in December. This followed the trial of the 'Fitzwilliam 9'. Arrested after a day of police brutality and peoples resistance in Fitzwilliam on July 9th 7 of the 9 were found guilty at their trial at Pontefract in December.

Magistrate David Loy — self avowedly 'judge and jury' — ignored overwhelming evidence of police brutality. For example defendant Peter Doody was so severely beaten by truncheon wielding police that he sustained no less than 15 weals on his back and had to spend 2 nights in hospital.

Loy found him guilty of 'Breach of the Peace' and gave him a four month suspended sentence.

Peter Hurst, an unemployed builder, was sentenced to six months imprisonment.

The Fitzwilliam Prisoners Aid Committee are working to ensure that people like Peter Hurst, who have given so much for the miners cause, are not forgotten and abandoned in prison. They write to prisoners, send them literature, money, etc., help them and their relatives. They are producing a monthly leaflet with the names and addresses of prisoners, to encourage people to write to them.

The F.P.A.C. is supporting ALL imprisoned for their support of the miners strike, no matter where they were arrested or for what alleged offence.

If you know of any people imprisoned for their support of the strike please inform the F.P.A.C.

Donations would be much appreciated. Write: Fitzwilliam Prisoners Aid Committee, c/o 4 Rockingham St., Fitzwilliam, Pontefract, West Yorkshire.

Another similar group has just been formed in London. Involved in the same sort of practical solidarity with the prisoners and their relatives, Class War Prisoners Aid stand for:

1. Unconditional defence of ALL prisoners arrested, in connection with ANY offences in support of the miners struggle.

2. Opposition to all attempts by Union bureaucrats to restrict solidarity with prisoners (as Yorkshire N.U.M. did with the 'Fitzwilliam 9')

3. No separation between 'political' class war prisoners and imprisoned 'common criminals'. Most working class prisoners are inside for petty crimes against capitalist property. For maximum solidarity between prisoners, workers and the unemployed.

4. Only working class solidarity can free the prisoners. For a fuller explanation of their aims and activities contact Class War Prisoners Aid, Box CWPA, 355 Holloway Rd., LONDON N7

Please send messages of support to the following prisoners, jailed for their involvement in the miners struggle. (It's advisable to write recorded delivery).

TERRY FRENCH, B73383, HMP Wandsworth, PO BOX 757, Heathfield Road, London SW18

PETER HURST, G78282, HMP Haverigg Millam, Cumberland.

GARY MILLWARD, S.NEATH, A.VIRGO HMP Armley, Leeds LS12 2TJ

A full list of prisoners is available from the two Prisoners Aid groups listed in Counter Information.